

Early Recognition¹

Naturalistic critics like to assume that the New Testament writings were not recognized as Scripture when they first appeared and thus, through the consequent carelessness in transcription, the text was confused and the original wording ‘lost’ (in the sense that no one knew for sure what it was) at the very start. Thus Colwell said: “Most of the manuals and handbooks now in print (including mine!) will tell you that these variations were the fruit of careless treatment which was possible because the books of the New Testament had not yet attained a strong position as ‘Bible’.”² And Hort had said:

Textual purity, as far as can be judged from the extant literature, attracted hardly any interest. There is no evidence to show that care was generally taken to choose out for transcription the exemplars having the highest claims to be regarded as authentic, if indeed the requisite knowledge and skill were forthcoming.³

Rather than take Hort’s word for it, prudence calls for a review of the premises. The place to start is at the beginning, when the apostles were still penning the Autographs.

The apostolic period

It is clear that the apostle Paul, at least, considered his writings to have divine authority; we may begin with Romans 16:24-25. “Now to Him who has power to establish you according to my Gospel and the proclamation of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery kept secret through long ages, but now revealed and made known through the prophetic Scriptures, according to the command of the eternal God, with a view to obedience of faith among all ethnic nations.”⁴ Paul declares that **now**, in his day, revelation was happening “through the prophetic Scriptures, according to the command of the eternal God”, and those Scriptures included the Gospel that he, Paul, was preaching, and “the proclamation

¹ From this point on, this Part I is basically a reproduction (with a few embellishments) of most of Chapter 5 in my book, *The Identity of the New Testament Text IV*, available from Amazon.com, as well as from my site, www.prunch.org.

² Colwell, *What is the Best New Testament?*, p. 53. [He subsequently changed his mind.]

³ B.F. Westcott and F.J.A. Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek* (2 vols.; London: Macmillan and Co., 1881), II, “Introduction”, p. 9. Cf. p. 7. It is clear that Hort regarded the “extant literature” as representative of the textual picture in the early centuries. This gratuitous and misleading idea continues to be an important factor in the thinking of some scholars today.

⁴ According to 95% of the Greek manuscripts, the correct position for 16:24-26 is 14:24-26, while the wording remains exactly the same.